

Q I'm so huge I feel like I must be close now. Are there signs that can tell me if my labor could start before too long?

Even before you experience the symptoms of actually going into labor, if you know what to look for, you could notice your body signaling that labor is only weeks or days away.

This table describes some of the most reliable indications that your labor is approaching. The signs are organized from the very earliest possible indications at the top, to those symptoms that you should call your doctor about at the bottom. Remember that it's impossible to be prescriptive about the character of every woman's labor, and even

signs that seem genuine may stop and start, while others may not appear at all. Listen to your body, but reassure yourself that labor is impossible to miss—you'll know when it's happening! If you're at all worried or unsure, never hesitate to call your doctor, who can offer you reassurance and guidance as necessary.

EARLY SIGNS OF APPROACHING LABOR

SIGN OF LABOR	SYMPTOMS	HOW SOON WILL I MEET MY BABY?	ACTION
Nesting	An uncontrollable urge to clean, tidy, shop, make; a burst of energy; an overwhelming urge to protect your belly and other family members.	Could be days or weeks.	Try not to overdo it, and make sure that every energy burst is followed with quality rest; eat little and often, and drink plenty; keep an eye out for other labor signs.
Lightening	A feeling of being able to breathe more deeply yet increased pressure on your bladder and/or pelvic pressure.	Could be days or weeks.	Let your doctor know about this feeling at your next prenatal appointment; he or she will assess your baby's position.
Sleeplessness	Difficulty sleeping despite being tired; waking in the night; alarming dreams.	Could be days or weeks.	See pages 114–15 for advice on getting more and better-quality sleep.
Practice contractions/ Braxton Hicks	Erratic tightening across the abdomen; belly feels rigid when you touch it; discomfort but not pain.	More numerous practice contractions, or Braxton Hicks contractions, as you approach your due date can certainly indicate that your body is preparing for labor, but there's no need to assume that labor might be imminent.	If you're worried, unsure, or have any bright-red bleeding or abdominal pain, or if you think your water has broken (see p.206), call your doctor. Don't be anxious about possibly raising a false alarm.
Lower back pain	A dull, persistent ache across the lower portion of your back.	Lower back pain close to your due date can be a sign that your cervix is beginning to dilate; labor may be a few days away, or perhaps less.	Call the doctor if back pain is accompanied by abdominal pain or cramping, or a bloody show (see p.206); ask your doctor if you can take acetaminophen for pain relief; distract yourself with a warm bath or other calming activity.
Diarrhea or feeling sick	Loose or runny stools, and persistent urge to go to the bathroom; waves of nausea or even vomiting.	No one is sure why—perhaps it is due to a hormone surge or your baby pressing against the bowel—but many women feel sick or have loose stools in the days before they go into active labor. Make sure you have everything ready, but your baby may still be a few days away.	Keep hydrated and eat little and often; call your doctor if you have diarrhea or vomiting that persists for more than 24 hours.

Q My belly keeps getting hard and I get a tightening sensation. Is this a contraction?

You could be experiencing "practice" contractions, also known as Braxton Hicks (after the English doctor who first noted them). If the tightening sensations are short-lived and last no

longer than a minute, if they come and go without any clear pattern, but are perhaps particularly strong after you've done something strenuous, if they are uncomfortable, but not really painful and if you have no other signs of labor (see p.206), the chances are you're having "practice" contractions, rather than those of active labor. These are thought to be present throughout pregnancy, getting gradually more

noticeable and more frequent as you reach full term. You'll probably really start to notice them in the last three or four weeks. Although they are popularly thought to help the uterus tone up for real contractions, some researchers believe that in later pregnancy they begin the process of effacement—when your cervix begins to open and draw upward, becoming part of the smooth muscle of the wall of your uterus.